Dad's Baseline, One Step at a Time

An eight-step plan for the family's part, with a line for who takes each step and when.

The goal: a dated record of what Dad does on his own, where he already gets a hand, what information the family has and which questions are still open, ready for whenever you next talk with his doctor or your care consultant.

Nothing here has a deadline. Share the list, put a name next to each step, and write in a date only if it helps. Tick each step when it's done.

STEP	WHO	WHEN	DONE
1. Ask Dad to describe what he does for himself and where a hand is useful. Write it down in his words.			
2. Over an ordinary week, note what he does on his own and where someone helps: bathing, dressing, eating, using the bathroom, getting around.			
3. Write down how he gets around, at home and out, and anything he uses to stand up, sit down or steady himself.			
4. Gather his current care instructions and recent letters from his doctor, or note where each is kept.			
5. Write down what you've noticed about memory, mood or how he communicates, each as one thing that happened, with its date.			
6. Keep a list of medication questions for whoever prescribes, or for the pharmacist. Leave the medications themselves exactly as they are.			
7. Note anything about eating, swallowing, continence or skin you'd like a professional to look at. If there's nothing, write "nothing noted."			
8. List the therapies or services he already uses, and who provides them.			

You're done when

What Dad does on his own, the help he already gets, where each piece of information came from and the questions you'd like answered are all written down, with a date on the page. What follows isn't on this list: a professional's review, the answers to the clinical questions, and when it makes sense to look again. Those aren't the family's to settle alone.

If it takes longer than you expected

- Let it. A step finished next month is still finished, and each note carries the date it was written.
- Leave a blank where nobody knows. "Not noted" is an honest entry.

- If a question comes up along the way that you'd rather not hold on to, take it to his doctor as it is. The rest of the plan will keep.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes the family's part. It doesn't certify that anything is safe, say whether Dad's needs are changing, or stand in for a professional's review.

Ready for the next step?

You've worked through the family's part, at your own pace. The care interview goes over the same ground with you area by area, so the parts nobody thought to write down get asked about too, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›